

Purpose and Paradox in India's National Education Policy 2020: The Catch-22s of Learning Reform

Anupam Raj, Columbia University, ar5099@tc.columbia.edu
Savneet Bains, University of Texas at Austin, s.bains@utexas.edu
Antarjot Kaur, Virginia Tech, kaura@vt.edu

Abstract: India's National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 envisions transformative, learner-centered reform. However, its implementation faces inherent contradictions. Using Deborah Stone's *Policy Paradox* framework, this study identifies three Catch-22s in NEP's goals: *technical expertise* versus *holistic growth*, *linguistic rootedness* versus *global readiness*, and *formative* versus *standardized* assessment. By framing these tensions as products of democratic negotiation, this study highlights the importance of acknowledging and managing the competing interests and values inherent in any large-scale reform.

Introduction

Education policy is more than an administrative mandate; it is a declaration of societal values and a primary driver of national development (Hanushek & Woessmann, 2008; OECD, 2020). These are inherently value-laden decisions that determine *which* forms of knowledge are prioritized and *how* success is measured (Fischer, 2003). In high-performing systems like Finland, success is not attributed to fragmented competitive reforms, but to a systemic coherence that prioritizes equity and professional trust over standardized competition (Sahlberg, 2011). Ultimately, a policy serves as the definitive script for a society's collective aspirations.

Yet, most educational frameworks originate in Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic (WEIRD) contexts, which may not translate to the complex governance of the Global South (Henrich et al., 2010). India provides a critical site to expand this conversation. As a postcolonial democracy, India is continually negotiating between local philosophical traditions and global market demands (Deshpande, 2011). The National Education Policy 2020 (NEP 2020) captures this dual aspiration: it seeks to modernize the purpose of learning through technical competencies, global linguistic readiness, and standardized accountability while simultaneously reviving ancient ideals of holistic development and cultural rootedness. It is a bold attempt to meet the world without losing the self.

This study also bridges the gap between the learning sciences and education policy, two fields that are increasingly realized to be interdependent (Penuel et al., 2022). While learning scientists often focus on classroom design, policy determines the systemic environments in which those classrooms operate (Coburn & Stein, 2010). Although prior studies have examined NEP 2020 from various perspectives (Ashokkumar et al., 2025; Batra, 2020; Deb & Lal, 2026; Govinda, 2020; Kulal et al., 2024; Muralidharan & Singh, 2021), this article argues that impactful reform must be both technically sound and contextually grounded (Fishman et al., 2013). By analyzing the NEP 2020 document, we demonstrate how large-scale reforms enable or constrain learning through the "Catch-22s" they create. Consequently, this paper asks: *How does India's National Education Policy 2020 construct and negotiate paradoxes within its vision for learning and assessment?*

Theoretical framework and methodology

This study is framed by Deborah Stone's *Policy Paradox* (2012). Stone argues that policymaking is a struggle over ideas rather than a rational problem solving exercise. Central to this framework is the tension between the *Market* logic and the *Polis* logic. The *Market* logic focuses on individual rationality, competition, and measurable efficiency. In contrast, the *Polis* logic is rooted in community identity, shared values, and collective flourishing (Stone, 2012). These are circular traps where two desirable, but incompatible goals compete for the same space creating a *Catch-22* situation (Heller, 1961). By viewing the NEP 2020 through these dual logics, we interpret its internal contradictions as inherent democratic negotiations between its *Market* and *Polis* oriented ambitions.

We employed qualitative document analysis to examine the NEP 2020 as a social fact. This approach views the document as a dynamic artifact that both reflects and produces societal meaning (Atkinson & Coffey, 1997). Following Bowen (2009), our interdisciplinary team used open coding to identify recurring contradictions, followed by deductive coding to align these findings with Stone's framework (Saldaña, 2016). Our perspective prioritized the real world implications of policy ideas while recognizing that meaning is co-created through

context and dialogue (Berger & Luckmann, 1966; Dewey, 1916). These findings center on three primary sites of contestation: the purpose, the medium, and the measure of learning.

Findings and discussion

The analysis of NEP 2020 (Government of India [GOI], 2020) reveals three structural tensions where competing democratic goals create implementational "Catch-22s." Using Stone's (2012) framework, we identify a recurring struggle between the *Market* logic (efficiency, global competition, and measurable standards) and the *Polis* logic (community, cultural identity, and holistic flourishing).

Theme 1: Technical expertise versus holistic growth

NEP 2020 (GOI, 2020) exhibits a deep structural tension between measurable scientific competencies and humanistic development. The policy identifies "*universal foundational literacy and numeracy*" as its "*highest priority*," driven by a National Mission (p. 8). This technical strand is reinforced by an emphasis on STEM, noting that "*mathematics and computational thinking will be given increased emphasis... Activities involving coding will be introduced in the Middle Stage*" (p. 15). This *Market*-oriented vision frames schooling as preparation for a "*skilled workforce*" (p. 3) to meet global economic labor demands.

Simultaneously, the policy invokes the *Polis* logic of ancient Indian traditions, where the goal was the "*complete realization and liberation of the self*" (p. 12). It envisions "*holistic and well-rounded individuals*" (p. 12) through a curriculum that integrates "*basic arts, crafts, humanities... and values, in addition to science and mathematics*" (p. 3). The resulting paradox asks the system to be at once expansive and rigorous. In resource-constrained settings, like a government school in Bihar (Kingdon, 2020), this creates a dilemma: does a school prioritize hiring a computer teacher for coding or a local artist for *Madhubani* painting? These "motherhood issues" (Stone, 2012)—ideals everyone agrees with—become difficult to realize because they require different support, curriculum, and infrastructures. Ultimately, navigating this paradox requires a contextual wisdom that empowers schools to innovatively bridge these interests, perhaps by using digital tools to explore and create local art, ensuring that technical training serves as a vehicle for, rather than a competitor to students' holistic development.

Theme 2: Linguistic rootedness versus global readiness

NEP 2020 presents language as both a tool for learning and cultural rootedness, and as a pathway to economic mobility, creating a tension between *Polis* (identity, belonging) and *Market* (employability, global access) logics. The policy strongly advocates for the use of the "*home language/mother tongue*" as the medium of instruction in early years to support conceptual understanding, while also promoting English and foreign languages to "*enrich their global knowledge and mobility*" (pp. 13–15). This dual vision asks schools to ground students in local linguistic contexts while preparing them for participation in a global economy. In practice, this creates a dilemma, particularly where prioritizing mother-tongue/bilingual instruction may improve early learning and inclusion but can delay access to English-mediated opportunities in higher education and employment. Much like Theme 1, this tension reflects competing policy logics that cannot be resolved through one-size-fits-all design. Rather than prescribing a uniform multilingual model, the policy's success rests on contextual judgment and the *agency* of local actors (students, families, and communities) to navigate trade-offs between identity and opportunity.

Theme 3: Assessment for learning versus assessment for accountability

Apart from discussing the purpose (Theme 1) and medium (Theme 2) of learning, the NEP 2020 also introduces a dual-track vision to reimagine the measures of learning. The policy emphasizes shifting toward formative assessments that encourage "*analysis, critical thinking, and conceptual clarity*" (p. 17). Aligned with the *Polis* logic of holistic growth, it proposes a "*360-degree progress card*" and redesigns board exams to test "*core capacities*" (p. 18). Simultaneously, driven by the *Market* logic of efficiency and accountability, it establishes the National Assessment Centre (PARAKH) to oversee uniform standards and conduct large-scale testing. This creates a Catch-22: teachers must nurture open-ended, inquiry-driven learning while preparing students for standardized testing. As seen in U.S. state reform models like Massachusetts, high-stakes accountability often undermines the very formative practices a policy seeks to nurture (Massachusetts Secretary of the Commonwealth, 2024). To avoid reproducing this exact pitfall in India, the key takeaway is that the implementation of this dual-track vision for assessment must structurally buffer schools from top-down testing pressures.

Ultimately, NEP 2020's paradoxes are inherent democratic negotiations between *Market* and *Polis* ideals, not design flaws. Realizing this vision requires moving beyond rigid, top-down mandates. Instead, systemic support must empower educators and communities to balance these competing priorities in practice, granting them the contextual agency to integrate technical and holistic goals for the purpose of learning, exercise linguistic

pragmatism in the medium of instruction, and protect formative classroom spaces from the pressures of standardized measurement.

References

- Ashokkumar, T., Russel Raj, T., Rajadurai, A., Abishini, A. H., & Anchani, A. H. (2025). Analyzing the impact of the new educational policy 2020: A comprehensive review of India's educational reforms. *Evaluation and Program Planning*, 108, Article 102515. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.evalprogplan.2024.102515>
- Atkinson, P., & Coffey, A. (1997). Analysing documentary realities. In D. Silverman (Ed.), *Qualitative research: Theory, method and practice* (pp. 45–62). Sage.
- Batra, P. (2020). NEP 2020: Undermining the constitutional education agenda? *Social Change*, 50(4), 594–598. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0049085720958809>
- Berger, P. L., & Luckmann, T. (1966). *The social construction of reality: A treatise in the sociology of knowledge*. Anchor Books.
- Bowen, G. A. (2009). Document analysis as a qualitative research method. *Qualitative Research Journal*, 9(2), 27–40. <https://doi.org/10.3316/QRJ0902027>
- Coburn, C. E., & Stein, M. K. (2010). Research and policy: Keys to a successful relationship. In J. D. Bransford, D. J. Stipek, N. J. Vye, L. M. Gomez, & D. Lam (Eds.), *The role of research in educational improvement* (pp. 167–189). Harvard Education Press.
- Deb, J. P., & Lal, D. (2026). A systematic mapping of the intellectual landscape of India's National Education Policy 2020. *International Journal of Innovative Science and Research Technology*, 11(2), 1865–1872. <https://doi.org/10.38124/ijisrt/26feb738>
- Deshpande, A. (2011). *The grammar of caste: Economic discrimination in contemporary India*. Oxford University Press.
- Dewey, J. (1916). *Democracy and education: An introduction to the philosophy of education*. Macmillan.
- Fischer, F. (2003). *Reframing public policy: Discursive politics and deliberative practices*. Oxford University Press.
- Fishman, B., Penuel, W. R., Allen, A. R., Cheng, B. H., & Sabelli, N. (2013). Design-based implementation research: An emerging model for transforming the relationship of research and practice. *National Society for the Study of Education Yearbook*, 112(2), 136–156.
- Government of India, Ministry of Education. (2020). *National Education Policy 2020*. Government of India. https://www.education.gov.in/sites/upload_files/mhrd/files/NEP_Final_English_0.pdf
- Govinda, R. (2020). NEP 2020: A critical examination. *Social Change*, 50(4), 603–607. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0049085720958904>
- Hanushek, E. A., & Woessmann, L. (2008). The role of cognitive skills in economic development. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 46(3), 607–668. <https://doi.org/10.1257/jel.46.3.607>
- Heller, J. (1961). *Catch-22*. Simon & Schuster.
- Henrich, J., Heine, S. J., & Norenzayan, A. (2010). The weirdest people in the world? *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 33(2–3), 61–83. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X0999152X>
- Kingdon, G. G. (2020). The Private Schooling Phenomenon in India: A Review. *The Journal of Development Studies*, 56(10), 1795–1817. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00220388.2020.1715943>
- Kulal, A., N, A., Dinesh, S., Bhat, D. C., & Girish, A. (2024). Evaluating the promise and pitfalls of India's National Education Policy 2020: Insights from the perspectives of students, teachers, and experts. *Sage Open*, 14(4), 21582440241279367. <https://doi.org/10.1177/21582440241279367>
- Massachusetts Secretary of the Commonwealth. (2024). Information for voters: 2024 ballot questions [Pamphlet]. Commonwealth of Massachusetts. <https://www.sec.state.ma.us/>
- Muralidharan, K., & Singh, A. (2021). India's new National Education Policy: Evidence and challenges. *Science*, 372(6537), 36–38. <https://doi.org/10.1126/science.abf6655>
- OECD. (2020). *Education at a glance 2020: OECD indicators*. <https://doi.org/10.1787/69096873-en>
- Penuel, W. R., Jurow, A. S., O'Connor, K., Van Horne, K., & Bevan, B. (2022). Learning sciences and education policy. In R. K. Sawyer (Ed.), *The Cambridge handbook of the learning sciences* (3rd ed., pp. 663–686). Cambridge University Press.
- Sahlberg, P. (2011). *Finnish lessons: What can the world learn from educational change in Finland?* Teachers College Press.
- Saldaña, J. (2016). *The coding manual for qualitative researchers* (3rd ed.). Sage.
- Stone, D. (2012). *Policy paradox: The art of political decision making* (3rd ed.). W. W. Norton.